

“Dead” in Multicultural London English: A Corpus Study

SPC4004 — Assessment 3

Research Question

In Standard English, *dead* usually means “no longer alive”. In Multicultural London English (MLE), it gets used in other ways too. You can say “*dead funny*” for “really funny”, or call a boring place “*dead*”. This study looks at how often each use comes up in the London English Corpus, and whether different speaker groups use them differently.

Dataset and Filtering

I used the London English Corpus (LEC), a 2.4-million-word collection of MLE speech accessed through Sketch Engine. Searching for *dead* returned 215 hits, all of which I kept. The corpus had messy markup tags which I stripped in Python. I also kept the speaker info so I could split the results by group: 75 White British, 16 Black or Mixed-heritage, and 124 unrecorded.

```
import pandas as pd, re
df = pd.read_excel('lec_dead.xlsx', skiprows=5) # 215 rows
clean = lambda t: re.sub(r'</s><s>|<[>]+>|#[^#]+#', ' ', str(t))
df['left_clean'] = df['Left'].apply(clean)
df['right_clean'] = df['Right'].apply(clean)
df['demographic'] = df['Reference'].str.split(',').str[1].fillna('Unknown')
```

AI Tools and Prompts

I used Claude (Anthropic, model *claude-opus-4-7*) to help in the initial classification of the sentences. The full prompt and code are in the GitHub repository.

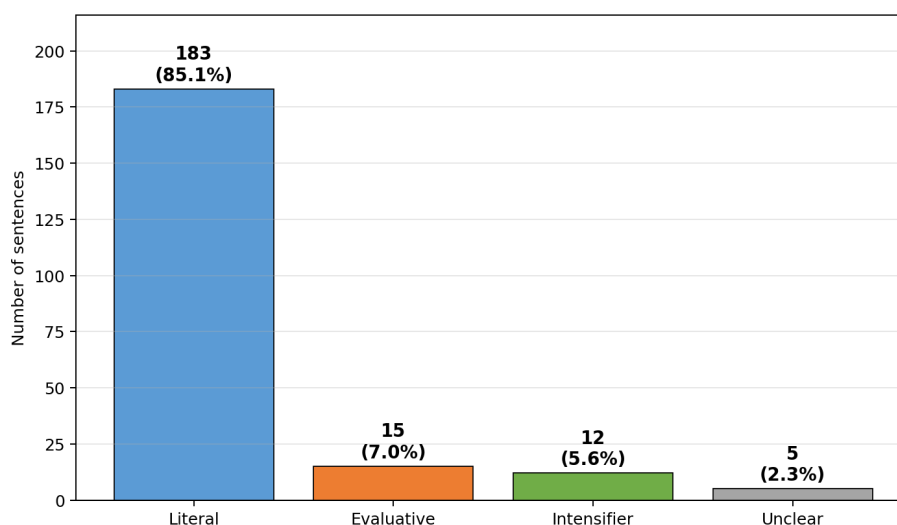
Linguistic Classification

Three main categories came out of the data (Figure 1). I refined my labels as I went. At first I was putting fixed compounds like *dead end* and *dead body* in the intensifier group, but they’re really literal. Threats like “*you’re dead*” I kept as literal too, since the speaker is still talking about dying. The final counts and demographic breakdown were generated like this:

```
manual = pd.read_csv('manual_classifications.csv')
df = df.merge(manual, on='id')
df['category'].value_counts()
# literal      183    (85.1%)
# evaluative   15     ( 7.0%)
# intensifier  12     ( 5.6%)
# unclear      5      ( 2.3%)
pd.crosstab(df['demographic'], df['category'], normalize='index') * 100
```

- **Literal (n=183, 85.1%):** the standard meaning, where someone has died or something is broken. Examples: “*he’s been dead thirty years*”.
- **Evaluative (n=15, 7.0%):** *dead* describes a place or atmosphere as boring. Examples: “*it’s well dead round there*”.
- **Intensifier (n=12, 5.6%):** *dead* makes an adjective or adverb stronger, meaning “very”. Examples: “*dead lucky*”.

Figure 1. Distribution of "dead" uses in the London English Corpus (n=215)



Analysis

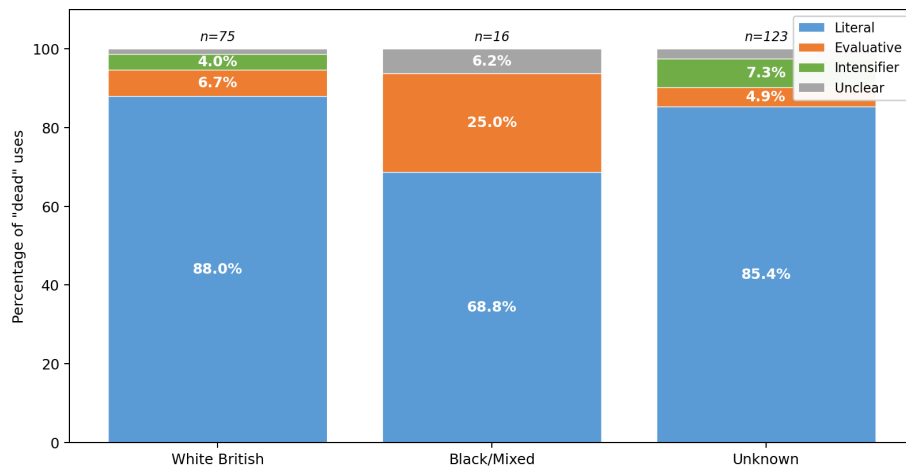
The data shows that MLE-specific uses of *dead* are actually quite rare. The intensifier and evaluative senses only make up 12.6% of examples, while the literal meaning takes up 85.1%. This is probably because the LEC was recorded in both Hackney and Havering, and includes many older White British speakers who use *dead* in the standard way.

Figure 2 shows something interesting when you split the results by speaker group. Black and Mixed-heritage speakers used *dead* to describe a boring place 25% of the time, almost four times the White British rate of 6.7%. The Black/Mixed sample is small (only 16 sentences) so this isn't a strong claim, but the pattern fits with MLE being a contact variety where Caribbean and African influences drive new word uses.

The intensifier result was more surprising. White British speakers also produced "*dead lucky*", "*dead fast*" and "*dead panic*". So this use isn't really MLE-specific. It's an older British colloquialism (northern dialects have used "*dead good*" for a long time), and it appears in every group I looked at.

So the two non-literal uses look like they come from different places. The intensifier is probably just a traditional British informal feature, not MLE-specific. The evaluative "*place is dead*" looks like a real MLE innovation. Both pull *dead* away from death, but the evaluative keeps the metaphor (a lifeless place feels boring), while the intensifier just means "very", like MLE words *bare* and *well*.

Figure 2. Distribution of "dead" categories by speaker demographic



Repository and References

Full dataset, classification code, prompts, and results:

Cheshire, J., Kerswill, P., Fox, S. & Torgersen, E. (2008). *Linguistic Innovators: The English of Adolescents in London*. Accessed via Sketch Engine.

Word count: 515 (excluding code blocks and references).